

OUR GURUDEV'S MESSAGE

Content

Gurudev Jayanti Issue



#FromOurArchives
Homegrown author Adithyan Diwakar Vidya (IB 2) receiving the first copy of his book ‘Dare to be a Zero’ from Pujya Swamini Vimalananda ji

Features

04 The Illusion of Choice

The Youth Economic Initiative brings us an article on choice architecture and the factors that affect our purchases.

05 Through her Lens

In an enlightening interview with our beloved Aashika ma’am, our team received thoughtful answers about psychology in social situations and the study of Psychology itself, especially in school.

06 The Alchemy of Action

We bring to you the continuation of the Alchemy of Action, a guide to life by the Gita panchamrit.

07 From Our Hearts

A collection of heartfelt reflections on the profound impact of Gurudev in our lives, from teachers and students alike.

08 Rumors at CIRS

Words have profound power - whether positive or negative, they shape our world view. How does gossip invade our daily conversations, and how do we eradicate it?

10 Crossbusters

A curated selection of books and movies, tailored for lovers of different genres, and some released just in time for our vacations!

01 Our Gurudev’s Message

02 The Editorial

03 Is AI - Art Really Art?

09 Itihāsa

11 Hot Wheels V/S Barbie

12 Need for Spirituality in the Youth

13 Geography and Geopolitics

Hare Om! Hare Om! Hare Om!

Salutations!

Continue your daily exercises for healthy and strong body. Plunge yourself in study and score the best you can. The future career depends upon your healthy mind and continuous efforts. Be regular in your daily prayers, and faith in yourself and in Lord's protection fearlessly enter into your chosen field of honest action. You will never know what is failure!

Love, Sri Chinmoy

Our Gurmudev's Message

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Love,

Sri Chinmoy



A word is not simply a passive group of letters, just as a language is not its dictionary. How does any group differ from this principle? A community is only as good as its members, and on a larger scale, a nation is what its people make it.

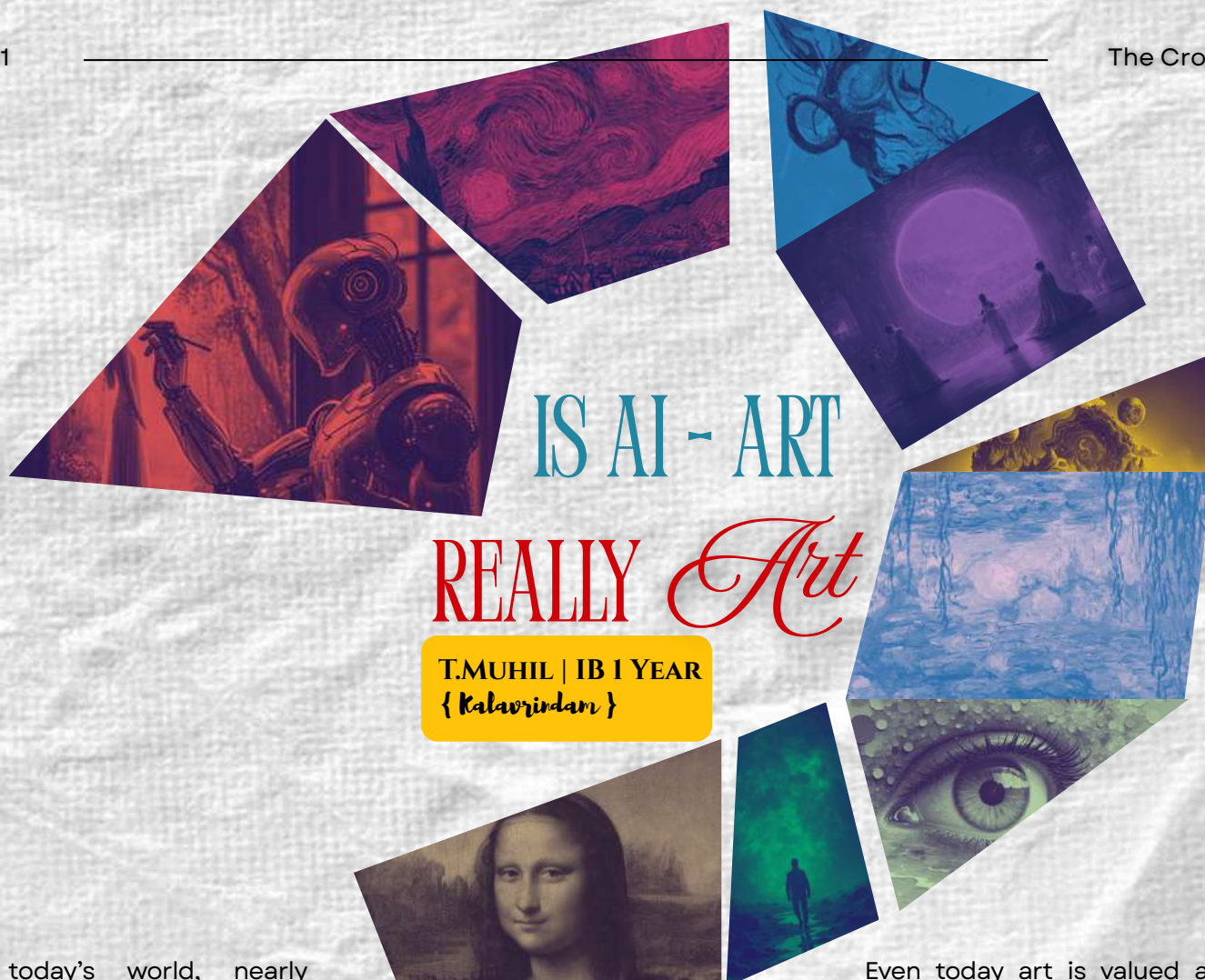
How many times would you have heard the same principle by now, while never once realizing that 'people' is us? Every student studying in school, every tired working-class citizen, every pompous businessman. Every year, students pore over the same textbooks, and the business owners make the same deals their grandparents did. We stay in a cycle of peaceful monotony, day after day, year after year.

In contrast, the world is constantly and rapidly changing. New technology, new wars, new implications. Shaurya Bhartia's 'Geography in Geopolitics' attempts to act as a compass to readers who understand neither head nor tail of the bold headlines in every day's Times of India.

CIRS has its own headlines, but the medium of communication differs just slightly. These pieces of information flit from student to student, reaching an astonishing number of people by word of mouth. We like to call it gossip. 'Rumors at CIRS' extrapolates on the amount of time we waste on this pastime every day, and how we can minimize the habit.

For all the creative, crazy art lovers, we bring to you a universal question: 'Is AI-generated art really art?' How much does the use of AI affect us right now, and what are its possible impacts in the future? These questions are equally relevant to other forms of art, such as acting and dance.

From politics to the Panchamrit, from interviews to illusions (in a slightly different context), this issue has something for each and every one of you. Enjoy reading, and have an insightful Gurudev Jayanti!



IS AI - ART REALLY *Art*

T.MUHIL | IB 1 YEAR
{ Kalarindam }

In today's world, nearly everything we do has a trace of artificial intelligence in it, from our daily tasks to our school projects. Even solving a simple math problem leads to verification from AI. We have become habituated to using AI in even the smallest things possible, so much so that it has become an inseparable part of our lives. Not to forget some countries have AI bots as their ministers! AI has recently also invaded the sphere of art in , stealing jobs of several digital artists and content creators. According to a survey conducted by the Society of Authors, about 26% of freelance artists lost their income because of AI.

This intervention of AI in the domain of art raises a peculiar question - Is AI-generated art really art? To answer this question we need to travel back in time to when traditional artists thrived. Art is considered the mirror of a society, defining the characteristics of the human species, serving as a universal language that has recorded human experiences, values, and emotions for tens of thousands of years. Throughout history, it has functioned not merely as decoration, but as a crucial tool for rituals, communication, social status, and historical documentation.



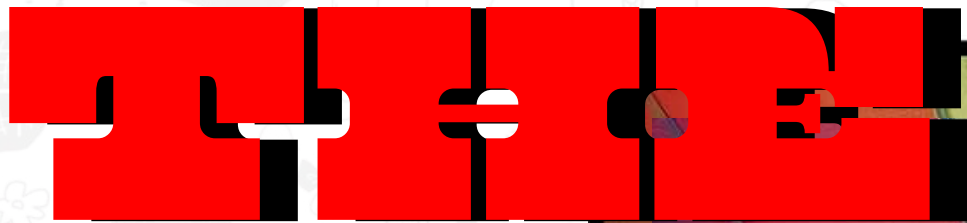
Within a decade, we might not have the same crowd navigating to the galleries of the Louvre to admire the mastery of the Mona Lisa as we lose this beautiful bond between a human and a brush. Our appreciation for true human art has reduced as we've start shifting to more AI-generated, lifeless art forms. The coming generations might not even know what Tanjore painting is! We are letting algorithmic efficiency take over the beauty of authentic human expression. This is a clear sign of our humanity itself deteriorating.

Even today art is valued at millions and is considered a symbol of status. An artist takes hours painting each stroke, constructing his painting with absolute precision, each painting carrying his emotions within it. Each painting whispers a thousand untold tales. But that is not the case anymore when we humans started using AI to generate art, we eradicated the very purpose of art. AI is a mere algorithm made to save our time and make our work efficient, but it has become so paradoxical that it started eating up the unique element that defined us humans for what we are - our mind.

Unlike an artist who creates from his own lived experiences, from joy, sadness, anger, AI generates mirrors of existing patterns and data. It doesn't have the same emotional attachment to the shallow art it makes. Art becomes beautiful when it has the human touch of imperfection, not when AI simply converts 'art' into a simple program that places pixels in the right way to make a 'perfect' version of the image. Let us make this clear - AI is a mere tool that should assist us with our day to day activities, we must not allow it to become a thief that robs our jobs, and more importantly, our thinking. Art without its human touch, ceases to be art.



Youth
Economics
Initiative



The moment we enter a huge supermarket, we see everything placed in such a way that almost everything is visible for a few seconds - and there is so much to see! From the rows and rows of colorful packages to the billing counters overflowing with small, eye-catching products there specifically to attract little children - candies, mints, bubblegum, the works. Remember those large cereal packets in the top shelf of every store? Those mascots looking down at you? They're there to attract kids. The same kids who pester their parents into opening their wallets and purses. A colorful package with just the right visuals? Careful design that can trap anyone into buying that product.

But the way the products are displayed: is it intentional, or just a coincidence? When you pick something up and toss it into your cart, is it because it's necessary, or because of the industry's mind games? Well, the truth is, the whole thing is a setup. The moment we enter a shop, we are part of a game where subtle marketing traps surround us, and the near-impossible objective is to leave the store with only what we were there to buy. These catchy products are placed strategically by people who study a subject called Choice Architecture. A subject simply about nudging the customer to make the decision you want them to make. Supermarkets aren't just buildings full of random shelves with products; everything is designed to gain attraction, trigger curiosity and increase profits.



ILLUSION OF CHOICE



The contents of a store aren't just strewn around blindfolded. There's a trick to everything around you. The eye-level shelves are filled to the edges with premium products and bestsellers. They are meant to be a signal of instant accessibility and affordability. Since these products are at eye level, they're usually seen first and are hence the most accessible, nudging customers to grab them immediately. Secondly, there are the products on the lower shelves, usually for the budget or store brands, which are often not as popular, as their sales are lower in comparison to other products. Then come the top shelves. These products usually target smaller children. Due to their small height, they tend to look up when they are in stores, resulting in their line of sight directly reaching these shelves. The products with eye-catching mascots, usually cereal brands, are kept above to gain the kids' attention. Additionally, the cash counter, probably the most interesting part of the store, almost feels as if you have just entered a chocolate factory. Filled with every kind of branded candy sold in the region, it is the one place through which every customer must venture, and yes, the store-owner has done a great job filling that section with every child's greatest delights. None of this is accidental: it is displayed after careful research about consumer trends.

The entire supermarket is a carefully designed playground, and the meticulously planned layout ensures that the customer goes through a variety of other goods before reaching basic commodities like milk, bread, and butter. Along the way, they are exposed to numerous distractions, which is a marketing strategy used by the seller, encouraging impulsive buying. What's interesting is that this doesn't force the consumer to buy anything, but nudges them to take the desired action.

The knowledge of choice architecture (there's an entire field of study dedicated to tricking consumers into spending money) lets us consumers be aware of this deception, and helps us make intentional choices rather than impulsive ones. So the next time you are in a supermarket, pause and think twice - do you really need to buy that product? Or are you unconsciously falling for invisible psychological traps?



What book is a must-read according to you?

It's this book written by Dr. Julie Smith, "Why Has Nobody Told Me This Before?". What I love about it is that it's a self-help book, but it's not one of the random kinds, like 'How to Make Money in 200 Days!' So, as a girl or a young adult, (when) I was really anxious, I got to the point where I was close to having panic attacks during my Master's degree. Back then, this book really helped me a lot in terms of simple self-regulatory practices. It is written in wonderfully simple language and contains some really amazing thoughts. Mostly, it made me realise how much self talk matters - usually in times of high pressure, our self talk is really negative. This book really helped me change the way I converse with myself.



What do you do in your free time?

I study. I love studying. Or whenever I'm alone in the house, I play Netflix in the background so I don't feel as lonely. Or I just play music and dance like a crazy person! I am basically my own entertainment.



Which curriculum would you suggest for students: CBSE or IB?

IB 100%. Because IB gives you a different experience. If you want to study in India or pass an entrance exam here, take CBSE. But if you want to transform yourself into someone who thinks, is curious, has research abilities, and wants to do something more, take IB. (*The psychology syllabus*) is based on psychological literacy, and its goal is not to create psychologists but to create people who are literate in psychology. That means you must be able to analyse biases, measure human constructs, provide basic mental aid, understand rudimentary human development, and manoeuvre around basic human relationships.

One beautiful thing about IB is that "Human Relationships" is an entire unit, where we can discuss in depth about things like internet relationships, which is, unfortunately, still taboo for CBSE. IB allows you to talk about yourself openly.



Aashika Aanie Kuruvilla
- Behavioral Counselor & Psychology Teacher

THE ALCHEMY OF ACTION

SANNVI BAGARIA |

IB I YEAR

(CONT. FROM ISSUE 30)

There are moments in life where everything you've learnt is no longer theoretical. When a small criticism from his teammate ended up affecting him more than it should have, Veer spent the whole night replaying the insult. The part of him that he had lost during his failures was slowly creeping back to him through little success, and therein lay the problem. Upon reflecting, the idea of offering his actions to something greater than him appeared to him in the form of a shloka.

॥ यत्करोषि यदश्रासि यज्जुहोषि ददासि यत् ।
यत्तपस्यसि कौन्तेय तत्कुरुष्व मदर्पणम् ॥

It meant that every action did not have to carry the weight of his possession. He stopped saying 'this is mine,' and the weight of proving himself swiftly vanished. Before the beginning his work, he would pause and say: *"Let this action not belong to me"*

Criticism stopped lingering the same way. It didn't disappear, just lost its grip. Approval did not cloud his mind, it stopped fueling his ego, when its volume was turned down. Veer experienced what it meant to act, without being the 'doer'.

For a brief moment, life almost seemed stable. Maybe that was what made what followed feel even more unreal. One call. That was all it took. A voice filled with urgency. It played with him abysmally.

A loved one had a medical emergency. And in that instant, everything that once felt manageable, did not anymore. Hospitals, expenses, waiting rooms and sleepless nights, everything became overwhelming. Veer was no longer dealing with thoughts he could control.

There was no preparation, no strategy and definitely no understanding. Yet, in that situation, something unexpected happened. Even without certainty about the results, things never stopped moving forward. Help came from relatives. Doctors responded. Situations shifted in small yet meaningful ways. It did not feel like personal control anymore. It felt like coordination beyond him. With that experience, a quiet trust formed.

॥ अनन्याश्चिन्तयन्तो मां ये जनाः पर्युपासते। तेषां नित्याभियुक्तानां योगक्षेमं वहाम्यहम् ॥

It meant that he was never really carrying his life alone. There was an invisible support he slowly began to trust. Slowly he realised... the world still revolves without his control. Plans still work without having to go through him. And that was when he stopped holding on so tightly; he could finally feel that something was holding him.

After this, everything did not become easy - action was just not carried out by him. After this phase, Veer changed in a rather subtle way, for he had become aware of what was beyond him. The constant need to interpret an event blurred and each ambition was thought of as a signpost to the path forward.

The final realisation emerged, not during a crisis, but in normalcy. He understood that the idea to “fix his life” was another form of control and that was when the final verse finally came into sight.

॥ सर्वधर्मान्परित्यज्य मामेकं शरणं ब्रज । अहं त्वां सर्वपापेभ्यो मोक्षयिष्यामि मा शुचः ॥

This was complete surrender, the end to a never-ending emotional foothold. It meant releasing the constant need to fix and define everything. He trusted fully, neither partially nor conditionally. Surrender was not giving up, it was giving over.

For him, this was the deepest shift as he was no longer fighting his own experiences. Veer did not transform into someone else. He still lived an ordinary life with mundane problems. What changed was the way his mind became tranquil. His actions no longer carried the fear of their outcomes, his suffocating control dissipated, and he finally connected with something higher - Himself.

He did not change the world. He just changed the way he lived in it. And by doing so, he became the quiet answer to every question he began with. These five teachings did not change his circumstances, just changed his relationship with them, and perhaps that is when Veer's story stops being only his.

'On a Quest' is not just a movie for me. Gurudev being the guiding light transformed my life from the North eastern part of the country to CIRS. Keeping me with a smiling face.
- Rashmi Ma'am

Thank you, Gurudev, for making me realise the true meaning of my name.
- Hasti D. Aghera

Gurudev's words, 'Keep Smiling' have become really inspiring to me, as they've taught me the strength to hold onto my smile even when things don't go my way.
- Prachi Sanepara

Gurudev has made me realize that everything is His gift and He has given me a lot more than what I deserve. For that I will forever be grateful.
- Naitik Agarwala

Gurudev's vision has provided me with an opportunity to discover my own talents and better myself.
- Aarav Maheshwari

Gurudev helped me realise my own self, what I am really made for, and leading me to great practices which I never knew about. He showed me a mirror and helped me learn to work on my own.
- Aditya Kansal

Gurudev's vision has given me clarity and courage in life. In the rare moments I really feel his love, I feel like the luckiest and happiest person in the world.
- Avika Mundra

Gurudev was the one who made me realise that knowing what you can do will make you perform better. Never do less than your true potential.
- T. Muhil

Gurudev is my Hero
- Shri Siva Kumar

From Gurudev, I learnt that before correcting others, you must correct yourself.
- Sivayini A

Gurudev's vision to spread knowledge to the masses is the reason I am here. This knowledge is something that I value deeply.
- Mahit Pinnaka

Gurudev has touched my life like a father who quietly shapes his child's values, strength, and direction without ever needing to stand in the foreground. His vision did not just educate me, it raised me with love, values, and purpose
- Aashika Ma'am

Gurudev is my Bhagwan.
- Hritik Bhageria



From Our

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Gurudev - my sole supporter, my support system.
- Brni. Bhakti Chaitanya

Gurudev's impact brought about transformation in me, pushing me to become a better version of myself.
- Advika Kumaraswamy

I prefer my teaching to be associated with patriotism, Indian Culture and Global Citizenship. Amidst the busy schedule, I should not miss spirituality. Gurudev blessed me with all these. In one line, "peaceful progressive life while touching happening young minds in a holistic way".
- Suvarna Ma'am

Gurudev opened my eyes to the profound greatness of our culture, leaving a lasting impact on my life.
- Krishnav Deorah

Gurudev gave me "Maximum Happiness to Maximum People for Maximum Time", and inspired me to do the same
- Viraj Lal

It was only when Gurudev came in my life that I realised the true meaning of 'harnessing' my inner potential.
- Ritika Deorah

Gurudev was known for smiling even in the worst situations. This is how he has impacted me. Listening to all his great deeds, I have begun focusing on smiling more and finding the best in everything.
- Shagun Parmanandka

Gurudev's vision is the reason why I have transformed as a person, friend, son, brother, and all my other roles. It is also the reason I try to give the same to others.
- Tanmay Khakharia

Gurudev - a magician. He never told me a word, yet brought changes in me through his everlasting teachings. Self-control, nobler vision, loving mentors and a conducive environment is just the surface of what I received from him.
- Divyam Gupta

Gurudev was the one who showed me that a single person's work can make a difference, spanning even generations, and stirring me to try to make that difference through what I am already doing.
- Rhea Sontakke

Gurudev gave me a vision to achieve greatness for the Nation and Hinduism
- Radha Goyal

Gurudev gave me Vedanta.
- Br. Sanatan Chaitanya

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Gurudev, a visionary, ignited a global spiritual revolution through his electrifying discourses ultimately uplifting millions toward enlightenment and self-realization
- Shreiyaa P Shah

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- Br. Sanatan Chaitanya

Hearts

RUMORS AT CIRS

AARAV BHARTIA | IB 1 YEAR

During the process of spreading news, or what we can call “gossip,” something very interesting happens. This passing of gossip becomes like the game of Chinese Whisper. The first person, who gets the information from the primary source, tells it to the second person. Now, the second person hears something, comprehends it differently, and then passes it on to the third person as something entirely new! When this cycle continues through a long chain of people, the news gets altered and modified so much that it becomes completely different from what it originally was. This is when the ‘news’ becomes a ‘rumor’.

Do you agree with me that here, in CIRS, news about people and events spreads like wildfire? Whether in late-night talks or Crossroads walks, we cannot keep gossip to ourselves. We all have the desire to tell someone about that one person or that one ‘kaand’ which we found out about from somewhere. Everyone wants to be the one who knows stuff and the one who reveals it. But imagine this: you tell something about yourself to some of your close friends, and the next day, every single person knows about it. Have you ever experienced this in CIRS?

It is very important to understand the impact these rumors can create on victims of these whispers. Rumors must be handled very carefully because they can either make a failure look like a hero or destroy a person’s hard-earned reputation. Can you imagine if something completely fake about you has become a hot topic for the school to gossip about? Can you imagine how that person would be struggling every single day to change everyone’s wrong perception about him?

Now the question arises: why do people even spread rumors in the first place? Usually, they make assumptions about a person or an event from the news they hear. Or, they are simply jealous of the other person's success or achievements and try to pull them down by spreading a rumor. If we are among these people, then we must reflect and ask ourselves some questions-

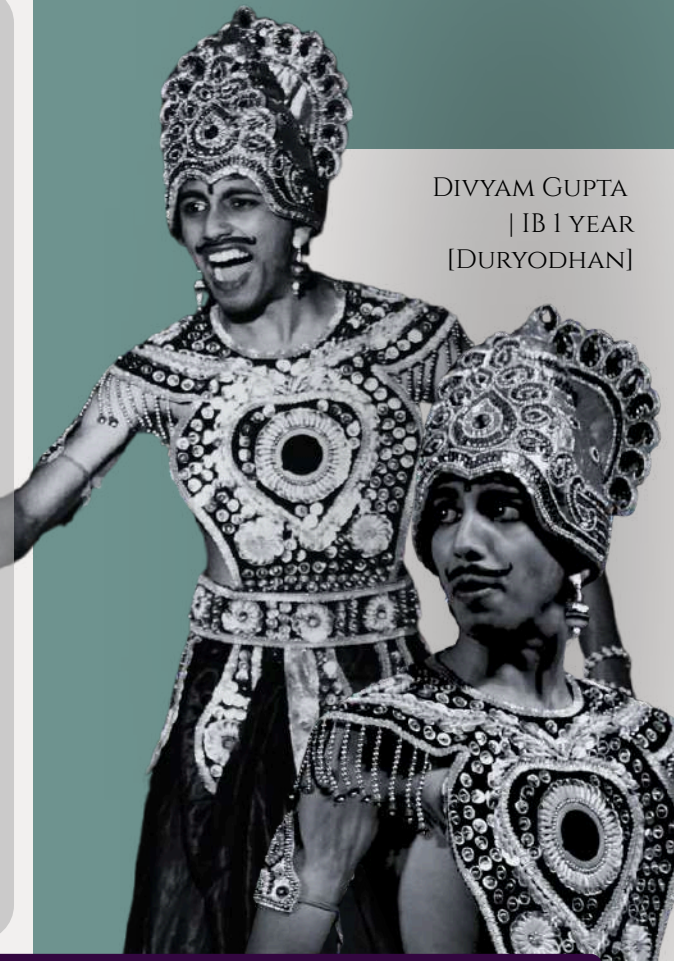
- Is spreading rumors or gossiping about people in any way conducive to me?
- Is it ethical to create a fake black mark on someone's hard-earned reputation?
- Am I letting my anger and hatred control my actions?
- Is it going to benefit the collective society?



When you answer these questions, you will realize whether you should be encouraging gossip or not. If we get some information about someone or some event, then before telling others, we must confirm it with the original source. In fact, why should we entertain gossip? It is a mere waste of time. There are better things to do in life. Remember, today when you gossip and spread rumors about someone; tomorrow it might be your turn.

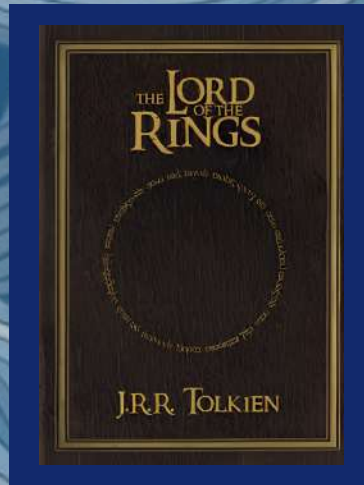
ITIHASA *-The Epic Choice*

To me, acting was always somewhat a decently tough job, made for those who can easily understand others. Having barely acted before - and even so only in roles which relate to real life - I never really understood the pain involved and control required for this phenomenal yet tedious task. Receiving the role of Duryodhana as my first major role was exciting and scary. Mostly scared, as every time I tried something or acted in a certain manner, it just did not work out. A week of practice passed and I still faced a jittery body, expressionless or overemotional actions, and disappointed in-charges dictating my work. And, by some divine intervention, my role in the play came out really well. Although it sounds like happenstance, what I learnt from this role was so much more impactful. Persistent effort and focusing solely on a goal actually makes a change. The late nights and the early mornings proved to me that hard work without complaint truly shows results, even if it seemed hopeless early on. To become someone or something, the mind should already pretend and behave as such, before the body can begin reaching that state; which, in this case, is to actually be Duryodhana a week prior to my acting as Duryodhana. This applies for any role, be it something noble, or something villainous. Lastly, I understood the importance of time management. Managing studies, practice for the upcoming tournaments, daily habits and the acting practice opened to me the vast realm of possibility, fueled only by the amount of effort and management put into it. I'm merely on the first step of a long journey. Chucking the small, unwanted things is where the secret of it all lies!



DIVYAM GUPTA
| IB 1 YEAR
[DURYODHAN]

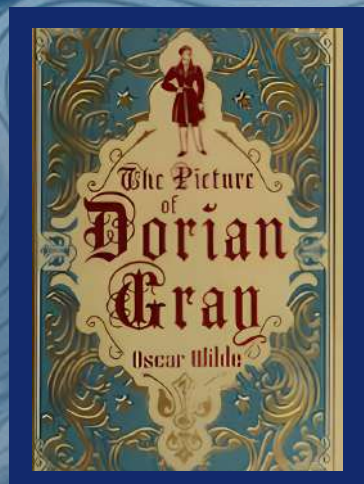
Hear ye, hear ye! Now that the summer vacations are tantalizingly close, we're looking forward to a long summer of lazing around, complaining about the heat, and devouring ice creams and mangoes by the dozen! The Crossroads Editorial brings to you another set of summer activities: reading by the window and revisiting cinematic masterpieces. From every genre and geography, Crossbusters is back! Movies and books ranging from sci-fi to history, and classics to self-help, we have something for all of you!



 Goodreads: 4.54/5



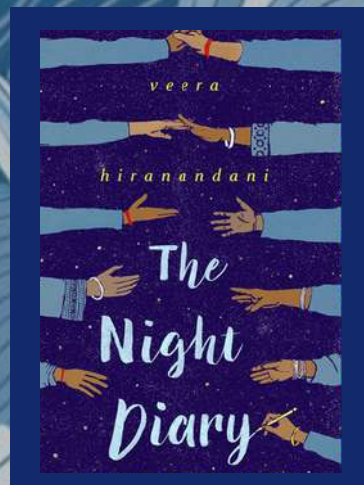
 Rotten Tomatoes: 71%



 Goodreads: 4.13/5



 Rotten Tomatoes: 94%



 Goodreads: 4.21/5



 IMDb: 7.7/10

HotWheels vs Barbie

PRISHA KANTESARIA | IB II YEAR

I am a proud biology student, and my biology class has a MEGA, WHOPPING, GARGANTUAN class strength of 2! And these 2 supercalifragilisticexpialidocious students are girls. 'Bio students, then they're definitely going to be girls.' That would have certainly been your first thought too! But if I talk about a big-shot neurosurgeon - most of us are instinctively going to presume that he is a man, a tall, hefty male who can cure your brain tumor by simply looking at you.

We can't really put anyone to blame here. This system has been with us since Day 1: it grew with us and within us, and got entwined in our tiny little brainboxes. From the beginning, spatial awareness toys like 'Lego' and 'Hot Wheels' have been marketed to boys and empathy-based toys like 'Barbies' and 'Dollhouses' go to the girls. This doesn't mean that we entirely stop giving Barbies to girls and cars to boys. The majority still prefers it that way. If someone would've attempted to take kid Prisha's Barbie doll away from her, she would've definitely strangled them with bare Barbie hands. Yet, somewhere, she was also always a teeny bit jealous of her brother getting the coolest, craziest, most exhilarating race tracks and transformers all the time. So now the question arises, what should kids like Prisha do? They love their Barbies, but also want to race a 1969 Pink Rear-Loading Beach Bomb or a Bone Shaker (for those of you who don't know these are Hotwheels) on the twisty orange track. Do they fall prey to the cognitive comfort zones created by the system?

Pitifully, yes. This 'system' continues to affect subjects like teens and even perpetuates to adults deciding on jobs. Research shows that when a large number of women enter a field, the average pay tends to stagnate or drop. Disconcertingly, when a male enters such a field, he often gets promoted to management roles faster than his female co-workers. This brings us to the Pollution Theory. Sociologists believe that the presence of a marginalized group 'pollutes' the prestige of the domain for the dominant group, prompting 'men' the 'dominant group' to split away from it, merely to preserve their social standing.

Women's professional skills are often dismissed as natural traits whilst that of men are considered as expert specialization. The most fitting example would be that of a chef, where at times gender eclipses talent, leading to massive pay gaps.

So what to do now? Kid Prisha's problem becomes adult Prisha's problem too! And let's not just limit this complication to the ladies. Somewhere, some XY-chromosomed Paresh would also be subjected to the same hitch. Is blaming the system going to reshape the system? The only thing one can do here is go after what they truly desire and strive to achieve it. A prime example of such a system reshaper lives right with us, our very own Bhakti Didi! During her Vedanta course, Didi was the only female in her batch. The only lady, amidst 17 men. She did it. She did her part in refusing to let the system change her future. And her story urges us to contribute in redefining it.

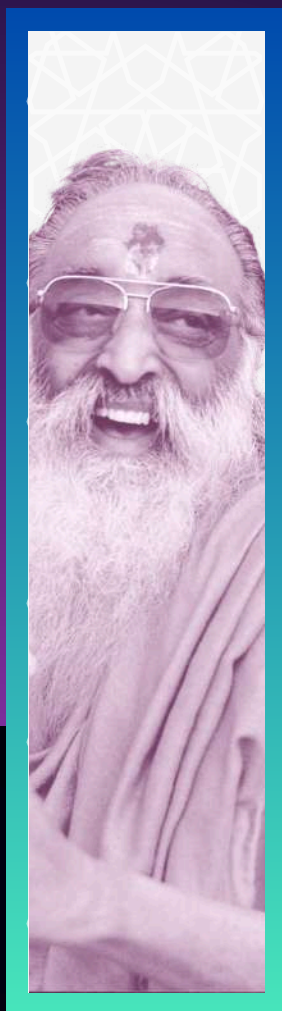
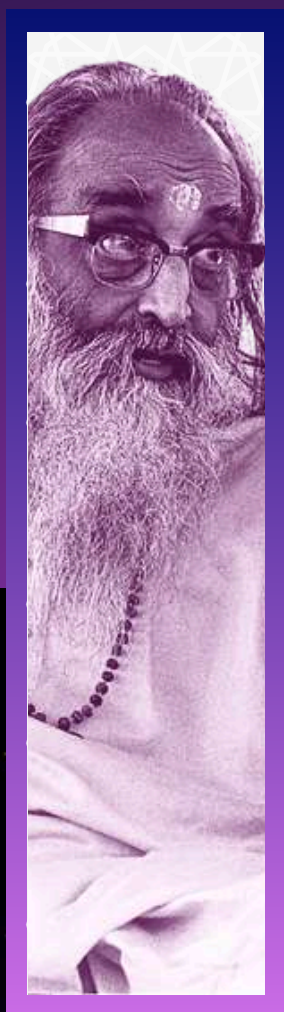
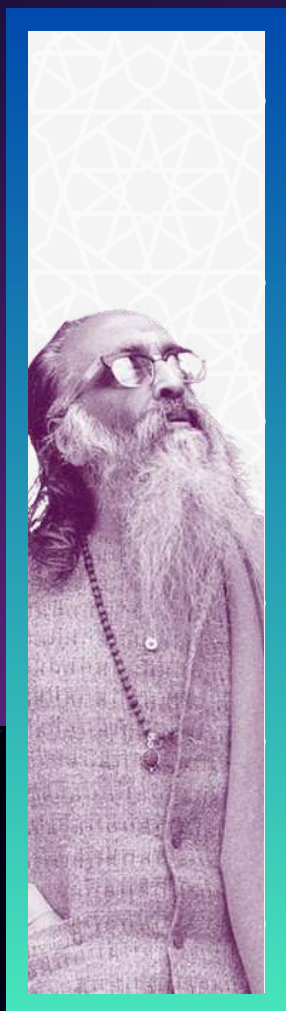
This brings us back to the system. The extremely misconstrued and misconceived system. Its original essence has been diluted through centuries of faulty interpretation. We come from a heritage so vast, philosophies so profound, culture which venerates Shiva-Shakti ... The Ardhnarishwar. The entire concept of Ardhnarishwar is based on the interweaving of both masculine and feminine energies. Shiva represents consciousness (structure and logic), while Shakti represents energy (creativity and care).

Ideally no field should just have Shiva or Shakti. A surgeon needs the technical precision of Shiva and the healing nature of Shakti. A software developer needs the logical nature of Shiva and the user-centric approach of Shakti. Gender bias forces people to suppress the other half of their nature. A society where men are encouraged to embrace their Shakti and women are empowered to express their Shiva is a society that operates at utmost proficiency.

So, instead of baselessly arguing that women should also do every single job, one should consider the biological sciences that once built this occupational framework. While equal rights and equal wages are necessary, it is crucial to understand the necessity for certain gender based divisions in specific fields, based on the genders' specializations and limitations. Some fields require a predominant Shiva energy, while others thrive in the force of Shakti.

The right career trajectory is adhering to these biological predispositions while parallelly prompting individuals to look beyond senseless restrictions, to embrace their Shiva-Shakti and to chase even their most 'implausible' desires - be it Barbies or Hot Wheels.





Need for Spirituality in the Youth

Gurudev Swami Chinmayananda

The youth of today have to be the very process of rebuilding the nation. We may have political freedom but we have not reintegrated our inner personality. In our teaching centers, knowledge is pushed into the student, proficiency is attained, but we cannot rise out of the gutters of poverty and inefficiency.

How can we walk out of this miserable state? Where are the geniuses and how to create them? For this purpose the Yuva Kendra was created, to teach not my own words but the words of the geniuses, the Rishis who wrote the Bhagavad Gita and the Upanishads.

The Chinmaya Yuva Kendra is trying to impart this knowledge, how to conceive and strengthen your mental qualities in whatever field you desire so that you may become more creative, assertive, efficient, and capable.

When I take a decision to win or lose, I always win. If the decision is correct, OK; but if not, I do not waste my energies by despairing over it.



GEOgraphy and politics

SHAURYA BHARTIA | 12 MGMT

Every week, we stare at the "News of the Week" presentation on the screen, clapping loudly at the second anything mildly related to India, any sports team, or Donald Trump that flashes by. But have you ever tried to understand what's actually going on behind those headlines? Or are you content with just having the worldview of a goldfish, only noticing whatever gets dropped into your bowl?

Daily newspapers and that weekly presentation are our main windows to the outside world. But reading the news and understanding the world are two very different things.

The problem is we only look at problems at their surface- who won, who lost, who launched a missile. But global politics isn't a culmination of random moves around the world. Every move is a massive, multiplayer, carefully structured chess game that is dictated by a very stringent strategy book.

Welcome to the **GLOBAL CHESSBOARD**

To actually understand this game, we need to stop staring at the players and start looking at the board itself. First, you need to understand what lies at the very base that forms its structure. It's rivers. Mountains that surround it. Because in geopolitics, the map is the script.

If you have been going through the newspapers anytime during the last 2 years, you would have recognized that Russian tanks are rolling into Ukraine, and Indian and Chinese soldiers are in tense standoffs in the Himalayas. On the surface, these look like two entirely different conflicts driven by different politicians. But if you strip away the speeches and look at the maps, both of these situations are driven by deep, geographically rooted motives.

First, we will move to Russia's nightmare. Despite its monstrous size, most of Russia's northern ports on the Arctic freeze over every winter. This cuts Russia off from a substantial amount of trade, and this also makes Russia vulnerable to naval attacks. To continue being a global superpower, Russia must have a "warm-water port" so its trade ships and navy can sail year-round. So why Ukraine? What's the prize? Simply put, it's the port of Sevastopol located in Crimea on the Black Sea.

If Ukraine permanently allies with the West, Russia risks losing its only reliable, year-round door to the Mediterranean Sea and, consequently, the rest of the world's oceans. Russia's invasion isn't just about grabbing land: it's a desperate fight because they are geographically imprisoned. They need that port to survive as a global superpower.

Now let's go south on the world map, and look at the India-China border. Here, nature manifested differently: it fortified India with the most magnanimous fortress, the Himalayas.

Since these mountains are so massive, a traditional, large-scale tank invasion between India and China is practically impossible. So why the tension? Because in this game, whoever controls the high ground controls the ultimate resource: water. China occupies Tibet, known as the Water Tower of Asia, and the starting point of rivers that quench an entire continent's thirst. India's geographic anxiety is that if China controls the peaks, it controls the water source. Now look at the contrast between the two - Russia fights because it is trapped by ice. India and China clash because their maps are too high.

The best part about this rule is that it applies everywhere, directly or indirectly. Once you learn how to read the map, the whole world starts to make sense.

For a real-time example of geographic leverage, look at the Strait of Hormuz. This tiny, 21-mile ocean gap controls roughly 20% of the world's daily oil transport. It is the ultimate choke point, exhibiting how a country like Iran can use a gap in the map to hold a global superpower hostage.

Why hasn't China simply invaded Taiwan? The US Navy is not the only limiting factor - it's also the map. To attack, China has to cross over 100 miles of brutal ocean (the Taiwan Strait) and land on a heavily layered, mountainous island with only a few muddy beaches. Geography makes it the hardest military to infiltrate in modern history.

Ever wonder why some resource-rich African nations struggle with trade to date? Their massive rivers frequently transform high plateaus into steep waterfalls, making it physically impossible to sail cargo ships inland. Transport is thus done through the shores, making the prices hike steeply.

These aren't just fun trivia: they are the invisible rules of the metaphorical chessboard. Every headline flashing on the screen is just the latest move on a board that was shaped eons ago.

Since we don't have internet access during the day to instantly Google the backstory of every headline, we have to use our heads. This week, pick just ONE international conflict from the newspaper in the common room or from the "News of the Week" on Saturday.

Instead of just accepting what happened, go find an atlas or a map in the library. Look at the terrain where the headline is taking place. Is there a river? A mountain range? A narrow gap of sea? Ask yourself: If this mountain or river weren't here, would these two countries still be fighting? Don't assume and create your own inferences from it; make sure you put forth the practicality of that being the motive before concluding.

It's time to stop simply watching the news and start reading the map.





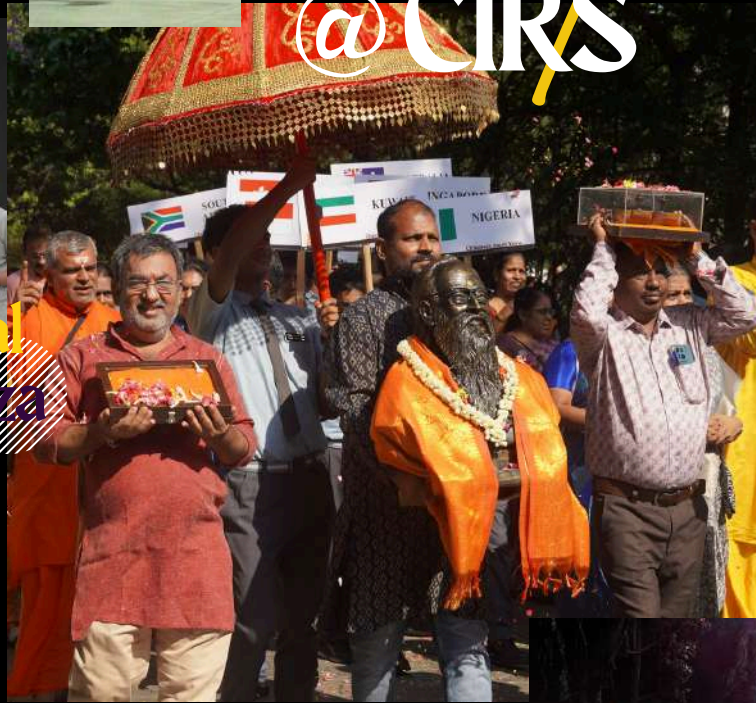
ARRAY OF SPORTS



Captures @CIRS



Cultural Bonanza



2026



Chinmaya Cricket Knockout

March



Teamwork



Smash it.



CREATIVE CORNER



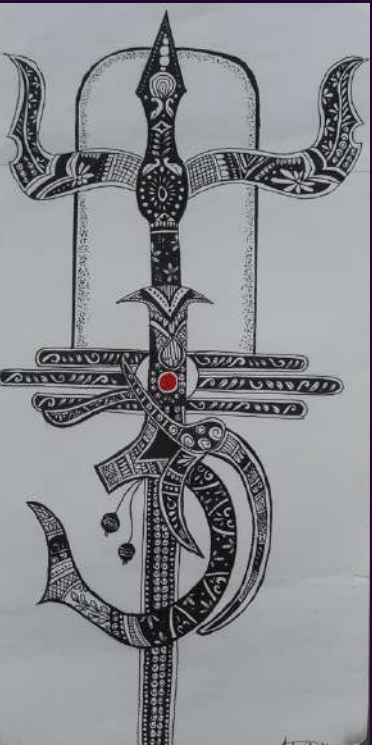
Pirai Soodan ~ IX 🌸



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Pranitha K ~ VIII 🌸



Adira Chellam ~ IX 🌸



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Ashmi A ~ IX 🌸



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Living In Awareness of Infinity | May 2026

'Living in Awareness of Infinity' is the ultimate goal of Chinmayam. Most of our stress, fear, and competition come from a sense of 'finitude'—the belief that resources, time, and even our own lives are limited. Awareness of Infinity shatters these walls.

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Living in Awareness of *Infinity*



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Our gratitude to the CIRS management for giving flight to our initiative.

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